Essays Two

LYDIA DAVIS

ON PROUST,

TRANSLATION,

FOREIGN LANGUAGES

AND THE CITY OF ARLES

HAMISH HAMILTON
an imprint of
PENGUIN BOOKS

Copyrighted Material

Twenty-One Pleasures of Translating (and a Silver Lining)

The translation problems that you have struggled with the hardest, perhaps never satisfied with your solutions, will stay with you for a long time—you can count on it. A few years ago, in June, on a trip to France, I was taken by French friends for a wine-tasting in the small Burgundian town of Beaune, south of Dijon. During the wine-tasting, we were at one point instructed to *mâchez le vin*—I can't remember now whether this was while we still held the wine in our mouths, or after we had swallowed or spat it out. Now, when this phrase was spoken, I became instantly alert, my translator-antennae going up: using the verb *mâcher*, "chew," for something that you can't actually chew was a problem I had spent several hours on during my translating of *Madame Bovary* some seven years before. The word occurs in a passage near the beginning of the novel, when Charles Bovary, at least, is still happy in his marriage, and Emma is not yet obviously restless or unhappy. This passage very well illustrates Flaubert's antiromanticism:

Copyrighted Material

> *Et alors, sur la grande route qui étendait sans en finir son long ruban de poussière, par les chemins creux où les arbres se courbaient en berceaux, dans les sentiers dont les blés lui montaient jusqu'aux genoux, avec le soleil sur ses épaules et l'air du matin à ses narines, le coeur plein des félicités de la nuit, l'esprit tranquille, la chair contente, il s'en allait ruminant son bonheur, comme ceux qui mâchent encore, après dîner, le goût des truffes qu'ils digèrent.*

This was how I translated it:

> And then, on the road stretching out before him in an endless ribbon of dust, along sunken lanes over which the trees bent like an arbor, in paths where the wheat rose as high as his knees, with the sun on his shoulders and the morning air in his nostrils, his heart full of the joys of the night, his spirit at peace, his flesh content, he would ride along ruminating on his happiness, like a man continuing to chew, after dinner, the taste of the truffles he is digesting.

I like to reproduce the word order, and the order of ideas, of the original whenever possible. Flaubert ends this otherwise-lyrical paragraph with the words *truffes* and *digèrent*—in other words, his rhetorical buildup, in describing the sensuous, placid happiness of a man in love, ends with a reference to digestion and a black, smelly fungus. This is typical of Flaubert, who likes to create a traditional writerly effect, romantic or sentimental, and then, when we are well entranced, bring us back down to reality with a thud by offering us a mundane, preferably earthy image—truffles in this scene, potatoes in a later one.

Copyrighted Material

The problem for me, however, was the word *mâchent*, which I translated as "chew." Of course I wanted to retain the idea of chewing, especially since it follows the lovely "ruminating," which is not only an apt word for Charles's idle thoughts, as his horse ambles along, but also yet another veiled reference to one of Flaubert's favorite metaphors—the bovine—which makes regular appearances in his work, even in character names such as Bovary and Bouvard.

But how do you chew a taste?

What I did not do, during the wine-tasting in Beaune—a cause for some lost sleep once I returned home—was ask the professional who was assisting us on our tour just how *he* translates *mâcher* into English, for English-speaking visitors, since there must be an accepted translation for this in the wine-tasting world, at least.

Still, the experience answered one question—the word *mâcher*, unlike "chew," can be used for something that, in my opinion, you don't chew.

In translating, you pose yourself a question—or it is posed to you by the text; you have no satisfactory answer, though you put something down on paper, and then years later the answer may turn up. Certainly you never forget the question.

I have had two literary occupations, and preoccupations, all my adult life, both evidently necessary to me, each probably enhancing the other—writing and translating. And this is one of the differences between them: in translation, you are writing, yes, but not only writing—you are also solving, or trying to solve, a set problem not of your own creation. The problem can't be evaded, as it can in your own writing, and it may haunt you later.

So, here we have the first two pleasures of translating: (1) the pleasure of writing; and (2) the pleasure of solving a puzzle.

Copyrighted Material

1) In translating, you are forming phrases and sentences that please you at least to some extent and most of the time. You have the pleasure of working with sound, rhythm, image, rhetoric, the shape of a paragraph, tone, voice. And—an important difference—you have this writing pleasure within the island of the given text, within its distinct perimeter. You are not beset by that very uncomfortable anxiety, the anxiety of invention, the commitment to invent a piece of work yourself, one that may succeed but may also fail, and whose success or failure is unpredictable.

I am writing, but not my own work. The words are my choices, but only within limits. I am working very hard at one aspect of writing, but I am not, altogether, the writer of this passage. I can work as hard and as happily as I like at this writing without the more general *doubt* that might accompany, even if ever so subtly or faintly, any writing wholly my own. Or perhaps it is not so much doubt as the *tension* that this thing may not even come into existence, or that if it falters its way into existence it may not deserve to survive. Whereas there is no doubt that this French sentence before me must be written, in English, and be written in this way: now I can apply myself to doing it.

In this sort of writing, there is no blank page to worry about, when you sit down to write. Someone else has already written what you are about to write, someone else is giving you closely specific "guidelines"—in other words, the original text.

It is also a kind of writing you can do when you are blocked in your own writing. Roland Barthes is quoted by Kate Briggs in her fine book on translation, *This Little Art*, saying, in his lecture course on the novel: "I would advise a

Copyrighted Material

young writer who is having difficulty writing—if it's friendly to offer advice—that he should stop writing for himself for a while and do translations, that he should translate good literature, and one day he will discover that he is writing with an ease he didn't have before." This was, in fact, exactly my situation—blocked in my own writing—when I began translating Maurice Blanchot for the first time.

2) In translating, then, you are at the same time always solving a problem. It may be a word problem, an ingenious, complicated word problem that requires not only a good deal of craft but some art or artfulness in its solution. And yet, though the problem is embedded in a text of great inherent interest, even importance, it always retains some of the same appeal as those problems posed by much simpler or more intellectually limited word puzzles in the daily or Sunday paper or in a slim book picked up at a train station—a crossword, a Jumble, a code.

Margaret Jull Costa, writing about translating the work of Javier Marías, in one of the Sylph Editions Cahiers series on translation and writing, discusses a particular problem she struggled with, and then concludes: "This, of course, is the kind of nerdy fiddling that all translators spend hours over—and actually enjoy." Eliot Weinberger, in his contribution to a very useful collection of essays called *In Translation*, edited by Susan Bernofsky and Esther Allen, calls us translators "the geeks of literature." Nerd, geek.

Example of nerdy fiddling: Here is not a complicated problem but a simple one. I must translate the final sentence of the passage about the steeples of Martinville and Vieuxvicq in *Swann's Way.* After the young narrator, sitting up next to the coachman, has borrowed a piece of paper from the doctor

Copyrighted Material

and written his piece about the steeples, he says, in one of Proust's wonderfully brief, simple sentences: "And then I began to sing." That was how I translated it. But before making that decision, I considered the alternative: "And then I began singing." The choice made me think harder than I'd ever had before about the difference between the effect of "to sing" and that of "singing." Although the two were so close, I had to ask myself in what way they were different, and which was more effective. We commonly use either form—"I began to realize" or "he began digging"—but I decided that if you are about to begin something, "to sing" sounds more like a beginning than the present participle, "singing," which by its nature implies continuing action. Rhythmically, too, the sentence read better with the closing iambs of "began to sing."

Further along in the same essay, Jull Costa observes something related but a little different: "What I say here is certainly not intended as a lament about 'difficult' writers . . . because I really enjoy dealing with 'difficulties.'" Nerdy fiddling with difficulties, or simply with choices.

3) A third pleasure, or convenience, is that translating is a kind of writing you can do not only when you are fresh, energetic, and in a positive frame of mind, but also when you are tired or cross, for the very reason that you are not under the pressure of invention. You can still be methodical when you are tired. I do not have to summon to this writing all the forces that I would summon to my own. I can puzzle out this one puzzle on a public bus with commotion all around me.

You can consult dictionaries and find alternative words when you are in a bad mood. This activity may even improve your mood.

Copyrighted Material

4) Then there is the pleasure of company versus solitude: When you are translating, you are working in partnership with the author; you are not as alone as you usually are when writing your own work. You sense the author's hovering presence, you feel an alliance with him, and a loyalty to him, with all his good and his less good character traits, whether, like Proust, he is neurotic and difficult, and at the same time generous and funny, or, like Flaubert, tender toward his family and at the same time full of contempt for a great many people and types of people. Perhaps it is that you overlook his less admirable qualities in admiration for what he has written; or your judgment of him is tempered by your awareness that you have a degree of power over his work—to do well or ill by him in the small arena of the translation.

You may also have company in the shape of a cotranslator or an informant—the native-language speaker who will guide you away from subtle mistakes.

5) Related to this is the fifth pleasure: You are to some extent disappearing from yourself for a little while, as you do any time you become wholly absorbed into an activity. You leave yourself behind for hours at a stretch, and this is not only a relief but an adventure. To quote Eliot Weinberger, again, from the same essay: "For me, the translator's anonymity . . . is the joy of translation. One is operating strictly on the level of language, attempting to invent similar effects, to capture the essential, without the interference of the otherwise all-consuming ego." (He does caution, though, at another point,

Copyrighted Material

that the ego can assert itself again: "Translators sometimes feel they share in the glory of their famous authors, rather like the hairdressers of Hollywood stars.")

If you are also a writer, you are all too much involved with your own sensibility, what you will invent, what your mind will turn up unexpectedly, what your vocabulary will be. The source of what you do will be your own self, just as, more physically, the source of a singer's voice is her own self, her own body, muscles, vocal cords.

And when you are not writing, you are also inescapably present with yourself, self-involved to a greater or lesser degree.

But when you are translating, your own self is set aside, you are subsumed into the author and the work you are translating.

6) So that is pleasure number 6, that in this activity you are entering another person—you are speaking in his or her words, you are writing what he or she wrote. You become a sort of shadow person, for a time, insubstantial. In this, you are like an actor. It is restful. When I am translating Proust I am no longer quite myself; I am here, but hidden in the shadow or subsumed within the identity of this other writer. I am only part of the whole of what I usually am. And it is a relief from myself. Weinberger, again: "The introspective bookworm happily becomes the voice of Jack London or Jean Genet."

You develop the ability, if you did not have this before, to be both yourself and another, or multiple others, at the same time.

Some translators concentrate on one author: more, and less, well-known translators come to mind—Ann Goldstein

Copyrighted Material

on Elena Ferrante; Rosmarie Waldrop on Edmond Jabès; Don Bartlett on Karl Ove Knausgaard; Michael Hofmann on, by turns, Joseph Roth and Peter Stamm, with intervals of Franz Kafka, Hans Fallada, and many others; I, for a few years at a time, on Maurice Blanchot, Pierre Jean Jouve, and Michel Leiris, with a number of others interspersed. Other translators translate always a different writer and so identify with many in succession.

7) You are entering not only the author but another culture for longer or shorter periods of time. Translation is a very deep sort of armchair travel—all your thoughts are taken up with the culture of, say, Normandy of the 1830s; or with Paris high society at the turn of the twentieth century. Don Bartlett, as Knausgaard, studies literature in the Norwegian Hanseatic town of Bergen or, earlier, hides his precious supply of beer on New Year's Eve behind a bank of snow; Rachel Careau, as the peculiar and inimitable Roger Lewinter, makes a mystical discovery in a Geneva flea market or closely observes a (Swiss) spider; Susan Bernofsky, as Robert Walser, retreats into a mountaintop asylum and writes in a graphite script so small it is for many years taken to be nonsense. You are traveling, and you are, inevitably, always learning—and you have the stimulation of both.

This sojourn in another language, and in another culture and another history, is one I thirst after because it relieves me, for a while, of my own culture and the present; there is no doubt that I like the experience of having my mind engaged in this other place and time and in this other way of thinking for long periods of an ordinary American day.

Copyrighted Material

8) You not only enter that other culture, but remain to some extent inside it as you return to your own, so that even in your U.S. life, things you experience may jump out at you in French: you may open a can of *pois chiches* to add to your salad at lunch, or you see deer *brouter* in a nearby field, or you find that your closet is simply too *exigu*, or twilight descends and the time of day appears to you to be *entre chien et loup*. You think, at the Columbia County Fair, that perhaps this farmer, before walking to the exhibits, will knot the corners of his handkerchief and place it on his head, to protect himself from the sun—as do the farmers arriving at the great agricultural fair in *Madame Bovary*.

9) As a result of often stepping outside it, or spending long weeks outside it, you come to acquire greater perspective on your own native culture, with its particular history. You are always in it and of it, but you do not take it for granted. You appreciate the individuality of any culture, but you also notice—with no bias, you hope—what is superior about each; your own culture is not superior in every respect. You also like to imagine what it is that the French like about your own country. If I enjoy their sometimes rigid codes of conduct, they probably enjoy our greater casualness and freedom from constraint. I enjoy the impression I receive in France that every acre, even every square meter, is valued and used; they probably enjoy the vastness, and carelessness, of many places in the United States. I relish the history that goes so far back behind every settlement in France; they probably enjoy the relative youth of ours.

You are, in any case, not inhabiting exclusively and constantly your own country and culture, but are looking out-

Copyrighted Material

ward with a wider perspective, more constantly aware of the international.

10) Because, however, you are always drawing on the resources of your own language for such a variety of different styles and sensibilities, or—if you translate a single author—a style and sensibility and personal history quite different from your own, you become more and more knowledgeable about your own language and its resources as you work—from author to author, or book to book, year to year, decade to decade. Translating continuously feeds my own writing by, among other things, enriching my English and developing my capacities in English. The problems upon problems that pose themselves, in translating, require me to become ever more ingenious in my home language; working within these constraints requires me to become more adept.

I am not quite as much of a Francophile as some translators from the French. My own language is always primary for me, my first and greatest love among languages. French will almost always seem foreign to me. After all these years, I still can't fully assimilate the fact that one entire word, and a complex one, consists only of the letter *y*, that insect-like letter, that sort of stick bug or praying mantis. How strange, I continue to think—though it is true that, as I learn other languages, languages entirely new to me, French feels more comfortably familiar, like coming home.

Although I constantly hunger for the sounds and sights and grammars and oddities and cultural references of other languages, I continue to revel in my own language, the deep and rich associations I have with its words, phrases, sentences; the richness and enormous extent of the English vocabulary, the

Copyrighted Material

flexibility and malleability it gains, for instance, from the fact that the formal, abstract Latinate vocabulary is paralleled by the blunt, informal, emotional, concrete Anglo-Saxon. I look forward to the unexpected unknown word that will inevitably come along to offer me its surprise. (Recent examples have been: *swinking*, *scrag*, and *ineliminably*.)

I want to take the always slightly mysterious French sentence and transform it into something every word, and nuance, of which will be thoroughly *home* to me, which is what English is to me—the home language. It is the decipherment and then the transformation that satisfy me. So, much as I may love many, many sentences of Proust's or Flaubert's, I am out to annihilate them, for the moment, to replace them by something fine in my own language, what Virginia Woolf described so succinctly, in a 1937 talk on craftsmanship, as "the right words in the right order"—in English.

11) But, for translators who are also engaged in writing of their own, here is another great pleasure: Just as you can enter another person and speak in his voice, you are also no longer confined to writing in your own style and with your own sensibility, but can write in the style of Proust, for instance, with his elaborated syntactic pyramids, and then, a few years later, in the style of Flaubert, with his clipped clauses and fondness for semicolons. You are at the same time clothing yourself, for a while, in the sensibility of the original author: Proust's affectionate portrait of the grandmother in *Swann's Way* becomes my own affectionate portrait of her, in Proustian sentences. Flaubert's moment of compassion for the dying Emma becomes my own compassion, in English, though I may privately feel more sympathy for the often de-

Copyrighted Material

rided Charles, quietly meeting his end in the sunlight, on a garden bench, as he is being called in to lunch.

This phenomenon, of slipping into the style of another writer, gives you great freedom and joy, in your manipulation of language. You are ventriloquist and chameleon.

And while you comply with this alien style, while you fit your own prose into it, you may also, positively, react against it, in your hours off, your away hours: it was while I was translating, with such pleasure, Proust's very long and ingenuity-taxing sentences that I began, in contrary motion, to write the very shortest stories I could compose, sometimes consisting only of the title and a single line.

12) I search for the reasons why I continue to want to translate, or rather, what impels me to continue translating. I suspected, but wasn't quite ready to admit, that the fact was I really *wanted to write this book* in English, whatever it was: I wanted to convey those strange moments of Blanchot's *L'Arrêt de mort* in English, I wanted to construct those complex sentences of Proust's *Du Côté de chez Swann* in English, I wanted to tell the story and make the wry comments, in English, of *Madame Bovary*; I was charmed, and moved, by this story of Peter Bichsel's, and wanted to see it in English prose, though as nearly as possible, somehow, in just the way he wrote it.

In her contribution to the anthology *In Translation*, Clare Cavanagh, translator of Wisława Szymborska (pronounced "veeswava shimborska") and others, expresses, in relation to translating poetry (which she calls "impossible"), what may be at the heart of the translating impulse: "You see a wonderful thing in front of you, and you want it. You try reading it over and over, you see if you can memorize it, or copy it

Copyrighted Material

out line by line. And nothing works; it's still there. So if it doesn't already exist in English, you turn to translation; you try remaking it in your own language, in your own words, in the vain hope of getting it once and for all, of finally making it your own. And sometimes you even feel, for a while at least, for a day or two or even a couple of weeks, that you've got it, it's worked, the poem's yours. But then you turn back to the poem itself at some point, and you have to hit your head against the wall and laugh: it's still there."

Over the years, on the other hand, there were certainly quite a few books I did not love and that I did not want to write, especially early in my translating career, when I was obliged to take on whatever translation work came my way in order to earn my living. There was still pleasure in the work, but it was the pleasure of solving the word problem, and, more generally, the satisfaction of supporting myself honorably.

But two recent experiences—of translations I did *not* do—have convinced me that maybe it really is true that if a book or story in another language excites or inspires me, I want to write it myself in English.

One case: I hungered to translate Gerard van het Reve's *De avonden* (*The Evenings* in English, now at last translated by Sam Garrett), once I discovered it—a darkly humorous Dutch classic from 1947 portraying ten days in the postwar life of a fraught family triangle of mother, father, and resentful live-at-home grown son, in which, for instance, a plate of pickled herrings, green from having been left too long, its onions black, nevertheless makes an appearance at the dinner table. I tried translating a sample few pages, thinking it would not be too difficult, since it was concrete and repetitious, but my beginner's Dutch comprehension simply wouldn't have caught some of the subtleties in it.

The second case was the arrival in my house of Michel

Copyrighted Material

Leiris's *Phantom Africa* (*L'Afrique fantôme* in the original), published in an English translation by Brent Hayes Edwards, reminding me how much I had been tempted, many years ago, when the book was just waiting for a translator, to translate it. I did not take it on, mainly because of its sheer size: it is 720 pages long and weighs just under three pounds. (I weighed it.) But how interesting was this very long and personal journal cum anthropological document. Why was I not content just to read it, why did I want to transform it myself into an English text?

It is not that I think my translation would be better than that of the present translator, though in the case of certain books, I suspect—or I know—that mine would have been better. (And perhaps this—here's a last-minute thought—would be another pleasure of translating: creating a translation superior to an existing loathsome betrayal of the original and thus, triumphantly, getting rid of the travesty.) No, it is simply the desire to *do it myself*. Is this yearning similar to that of any half-talented musician, such as I am, to play this Goldberg variation myself, even though my playing is so much worse than that of any of the pianists I could listen to in a recording? Similar to that of the earnest, slightly tense-looking woman who sets up her easel on the bank of the Seine and paints Notre Dame for the ten-thousandth or hundred-thousandth time, producing yet another not terrible but not really good painting—the joy of *doing it herself*.

13) Another pleasure, in the course of the translation, in the thick of it, or even after one version has been published: You can share your translation conundrums with others. You may present your problem to friends over dinner.

The one I took out to an Indian restaurant was this: If

Copyrighted Material

Proust could structure a quite short sentence with subordinates in such a way as to include four prepositional phrases in a row in the middle—three of them with "of"—and four verbs one after another at the end, three of them completing subordinate clauses, could I do the same? I couldn't, though I went into contortions trying. The sentence I took with me in order to get help with it from friends, help that I didn't get, though the dinner was enjoyable, was, in my eventual (compromise) translation:

> A man's voice which he tried to distinguish from among the voices of those of Odette's friends whom he knew asked:
>
> "Who's there?"

You write to an old friend from high school who is now a plantswoman, can read French, and may know what Proust meant by the *vigne vierge* in the Bois de Boulogne that turned red in the fall. You have many exchanges with her about Boston ivy, English ivy, Virginia creeper, and others. (At another point in the novel, however, "wild vine" seemed the right translation for it.) Or you receive speculations from strangers: an elderly gentleman living outside Oxford who has read an article of yours in which you present a problem from the translation believes that it is not a ray of light on which the titmouse is bobbing, but the ray of a plant, because he has seen it out his back window. In this case, he may actually prove to be correct, whereas most suggestions, or corrections, offered confidently by non-translators—as I'm sure most translators have experienced—are *not* useful.

And many translators, I'm sure, regularly share conundrums with spouses or partners who can't help and who often can't even begin to understand what the problem is, but

Copyrighted Material

who must, out of loyalty, or compassion, or because they live in the same house, listen patiently to the translator as she goes into great detail about the problem she is up against, or the triumph she has experienced in getting this meaning into "the right words in the right order." I can see, across our bowls of breakfast cereal, that friendly, open expression combining willingness and bafflement.

14) And there is another pleasure, for someone like me who am not really a scholar—and that is the pleasure of scholarship, or one aspect of scholarship, or what perhaps just *reminds* me of scholarship: the very painstakingly thorough research into the material in the book I am translating.

Sometimes the research has been botanical, or avian, as in the instances I just mentioned. Sometimes, as in the case of my recent translation of a slim volume of Proust's letters, the research has been biographical or historical. But most often, for me, the research is into a single, even quite common word, such as *soir*, usually but not always meaning "evening," and the sources I consult are just a few, and mainly dictionaries. If I was mystified that the word *soir* in French sometimes means afternoon and sometimes evening and sometimes even later, the answer might lie in the fact that it is derived from a Latin word that means a point in time later in the day, like the Spanish *tarde*—also not a fixed time—so that *soir* really has the elastic meaning of "later in the day," whether afternoon, evening, or even later.

As I translate, I learn. I could make that a separate pleasure, but for now I'll let it remain part of the pleasure of being, or acting, the scholar.

Copyrighted Material

15) I was quite new to the writings of Maurice Blanchot when I began translating *L'Arrêt de mort* (*Death Sentence*) many years ago; I was suffering a prolonged dry spell in my own writing, and this was a good way to occupy my writing time and mind until I could write my own work again—as Barthes advised. And I was not a deeply dedicated lover of Proust when I embarked on translating *Du Côté de chez Swann*, but came to it by chance, being invited to translate it. But in both cases I passed almost immediately from the outside, being the respectful admirer of this writer, though not the ardent fan, to deep inside this writer, so far inside that I could not see the outside, and still can't see the outside. It was from inside that I traveled through the book sentence by sentence and physically came to know each atom of each word, rarely stepping back to look at the whole.

Related to this may be yet another pleasure of translating, one that I have experienced but had not articulated to myself until I read a comment by a reader/writer/translator on the *Words Without Borders* website, that he had started translating Spanish poetry in order to learn, from the inside, how the poems worked. So that is another pleasure: seeing more closely, from the inside, how a particular work of literature is put together. You are obliged to stay with it sentence by sentence, or line by line, and consider every word: you come to know it very well.

When I translated *Madame Bovary*, I saw more clearly, more exactly, the art and artfulness of Flaubert's work in that novel—his care with transitions and handling of point of view, for instance—and although I still didn't love the book the way I had always loved his *Bouvard et Pécuchet*, I became a dedicated admirer of it.

Copyrighted Material

16) Another pleasure may be the better solution to a problem that comes later, on second or third consideration. Proust was a great reviser, as we know. I had many afterthoughts, too, about the choices I had made, usually taking a perfectly good solution and trying to bring it even closer to the original, attempting to magically reproduce the original. Here is one instance, from the Proust translation: The phrase *catastrophe diluvienne* occurs in an early passage about the comfort of sitting before the hearth when the weather outside is bad, and for months I thought "catastrophic deluge" was a perfectly good translation for it, and really quite a forceful little phrase. And it is. I like the way it reproduces Proust's *c-d* sequence, for instance. But I was reconsidering it one day—always a little risky—and realized that I could both move closer to Proust's original and write a phrase I found more interesting and rhythmically pleasing by translating it much more literally—perhaps verging on the overly mannered—as "diluvian catastrophe," and both my desires for this translation were satisfied: to stay close to the original and to write it well.

Rereading a passage of my translation months or years later is always both painful and pleasurable: in the case of something I have got right, that I'm happy with, I relish and savor this phrase and that as I never would a phrase in my own writing. But I also wince when I read, yet again, a problem not perfectly solved. The compromise involved in any translation can be painful.

17) Another pleasure is hearing from readers who are grateful for your work, especially if your work makes available a book never before translated that now delights or moves them. I recently heard from a high school pal of mine that he loved the Proust *Letters* that had just come out, and because

Copyrighted Material

of it was now listening to César Franck again. Or if your work makes available to readers a classic that was previously obscured by a less than wholly faithful or readable translation (quite a few people, in the case of *Swann's Way*).

This pleasure is purer, less selfish, than that of hearing that your own (nontranslation) writing has delighted someone, because the good translation is truly a service, at the same time that it is a personal pleasure. You have opened the way, you have given access, to the work of another writer. In certain cases, you have introduced a wide new readership to a writer you admire.

18) Yet another pleasure (I keep finding them), which I discovered as I was reading for enjoyment a translated novel, is—after so many years of translating—detecting through the English what the original might have been. Usually, this is because the translation has remained very close to the original and is also, at certain moments, not quite natural English, though not necessarily for this reason unpleasant. This occasional strangeness can become part of the style of the work in English and create quite a charming effect, as in, for instance, a translation of one of Georges Simenon's Maigret novels. We have the style of the novel as it is—in Simenon's case, the short sentences, the short paragraphs, the prevalence of exclamations and exclamation marks, sentences and phrases trailing off into ellipses, fragments repeating information (as Maigret thinks it over). And then we have the occasional unobtrusive locution or expression that sounds—to me, anyway—more French than English, or at least not quite English, and that points me back to the French.

For instance (and I'm guessing, since I do not have the French in front of me—but that's what I do when I'm read-

Copyrighted Material

ing), if a bartender removes the head of foam from a glass of beer "*with the help of* a wooden knife," this might be, more naturally, in French, "*à l'aide de*." "I'm listening, madame" might be "*Je vous écoute, madame*"; "*She . . . had underlined* with a glance the inappropriateness of Mejat's laughter" might be "*Elle avait souligné*"—"underline" could also have been translated "emphasized" or "stressed"; "it wouldn't surprise me"(not unnatural in English, either) could be "*il ne m'étonnerait pas*" (a little more common in French); "in other words" might be "*c'est-à-dire*" (more frequent in French, and also possibly translated "that is"). I can't guess exactly which idiom in French produced "A whole other kettle of fish, that one!" but the tagged-on "that one" is certainly more characteristic of French than English—perhaps "*celui-là*" or rather, since a woman is in question, "*celle-là*." One last example, exceptionally, falls perhaps into the category of discordant idiom, and that is the exclamation of an old wife of a customs officer who lives in a mussel-farming village near the coast: "I say!" This may possibly be, in French, "*Ma foi!*" In any case, to my ear, the very characteristically British exclamation is a bit out of place.

19) So perhaps we have here almost a nineteenth pleasure—not just reading bits of the original *through* the English translation, but, in fact, for moments, reading both at the same time, the English primary but the French now and then echoing in the background.

20) Another pleasure, experienced quite a long time after I identified the third pleasure of translating (that you can do the work even when tired or cross), was this: it is not only

Copyrighted Material

that you can translate when you are tired or cross, or upset, but that if you have a long habit of translating, this activity has become such a comforting, satisfying, and familiar one that, as soon as you sit down and begin translating, if you are upset, you immediately calm down and are comforted.

21) The last pleasure I have identified is a little perverse but one that should probably have been obvious to me long ago, and it is this: the pleasure of reading a foreign text, coming upon a problematic phrase, especially one you have wrestled with many times in the past, and *not* being responsible for translating it.

A final observation will not describe a last pleasure, but perhaps the silver lining to a translation cloud. One frustration in translating is the restraint you need to show, having to remain faithful to this text, write this story using this sequence of sentences, find words for these words, solve this problem, refrain from shifting into your own style or, worse, expressing your own ideas. And there is usually not an exact equivalent of the original, or if there is, it is awkward, or unnatural, and can't be used; translation is, eternally, a compromise. You settle for the best you can do rather than achieving perfection, though there is the occasional perfect solution.

But I have the theory that, for me, at least, and perhaps for others, too, the frustration of this constant compromise may create a certain pent-up energy that is later released in the relatively free territory of your own writing, or, if you are not also a writer, maybe in your tennis game or your morning run. Perhaps all that richness of language and variety of syntax that we could not use in the translation comes

Copyrighted Material

tumbling out in our own prose, or if that is not, precisely, what comes tumbling out, surely our own new composition, or our tennis or our running, is electrified, or galvanized, by this release.

The French, in their outward forms at least, are extremely courteous—and outward forms can be a significant factor in harmonizing human relations. The French have a greeting or kind wish for every occasion throughout an ordinary day. Eating a sandwich with a friend by a French riverside, one year, I was surprised that more than one stranger, strolling past in the sunlight between us and the water, said to us, with simple civility: *bon appétit!* At that point, we became more aware of how, all day long, it was *bon* this and *bon* that—*bonjour*, *bon après-midi*, *bonne nuit*, *bonne chance*, *bonne fin de séjour*, *bon voyage*. One *bon* that we had not noticed before issued now and then from a waiter as he delivered the next course: *bonne continuation!* And so I will conclude my catalog of pleasures by saying to my fellow translators, and to all of us in general, hoping to absorb and retain the courtesy of the French: *bonne continuation!*

2020

Copyrighted Material